



Nothing Real About It

Orchestrated confrontations, bickering judges, squabbling contestants, questionable ousters and wild card re-entries. Reality shows are increasingly setting the stage for off-screen drama.

■ By Kimi Dangor and Jhilmil Motihar

When Rakhi Sawant wept on air that the *Nach Baliye 3* finale votes were rigged and smses were tampered with to give an edge to eventual winners Aamir Ali and Sanjeeda Sheikh, she was only capping a long list of controversies this season about how unreal reality shows are. She isn't the only one speaking up. Kashmira Shah, the witchy woman on *Big Boss* said she was paid to cause controversy in the house. Ousted contestant Pooja Bedi spoke out against unfair judgments on *Nach Baliye 3* and claimed that rivalries between two contestants, specifically her and

Sawant, were staged. Aparna Mehta questioned the voting system on Sahara One's *Jhoom India* and another celebrity dance show, Sony's *Jhalak Dikhhla Jaa 2*, handed over the winner's trophy to Balaji bahu Prachi Desai amidst much debate. To add to that, *The Great Indian Laughter Challenge 2* runner-up last year, Rajiv Nigam, had questioned the re-entry of Pakistani winner Rauf Lala after being eliminated in the semi-finals, but received no answer.

After all this, one question has resounded louder than ever—how real are reality shows? Siddharth Basu of **TRYING MOMENTS: Finale of *Nach Baliye 3* (top); Mehta in *Jhoom India***

